FROM THE
EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The old adage that every state has an army but Pakistan's army has a state is becoming self-evident in the ongoing conflict. The dastardly killing of 26 innocent men on April 22 in Pahalgam by trained Pakistani terrorists outraged the nation. There have been civilian killings before in Kashmir, even on the basis of religion, but none so cold-blooded as the methodical gunning down of men in front of their wives. India could not but retaliate. On May 7, it struck. Among its targets, all linked to terror outfits, were the headquarters of the Jaish-e-Mohammed in Bahawalpur and the Lashkar-e-Taiba in Muridke—both in Punjab. It was the first time India had struck in the heart of mainland Pakistan since 1971. Operation Sindoor was marked by precise strategic calibration. No military or civilian targets were hit, and New Delhi took care to emphasise the non-escalatory nature of its action. The message was clear: no more tolerance of Pakistan-backed terrorism.

However, Pakistan's army chief General Asim Munir, de facto supremo and ardent advocate of Islamist nationalism, decided to up the ante. On May 7-8, Pakistan targeted Indian military installations along the western front, from Awantipora in Kashmir down to Bhuj in Kutch, Gujarat. India retaliated with Operation Sindoor 2.0. Drones struck high-value sites in Pakistan, even taking out an air defence system in Lahore. Pakistan scaled up with missile and swarm drone attacks, including on the Jammu, Udhampur and Pathankot military stations, besides massive firing along the LoC. As the air thickens with the fog of war, poisoned by misinformation, the retributive cycle is fast climbing the escalatory ladder. Not something either side can treat casually. Each step up a rung is made with a keen awareness of the nuclear shadow that falls over it.

Pakistan is a broken country. Its economy is on life support. It is riddled with internal strife and insurgency. Its most popular leader languishes in jail. A hotchpotch puppet coalition is nominally in charge, but the real ruler is the army. To justify its relevance and create a distraction from its domestic woes, Gen. Munir has deliberately taken his country into a state of war. The traditional definition of war has to change in the age of modern weaponry. It no longer has to entail the mass mobilisation of troops with the objective of taking territory. Today's wars can be fought without crossing borders, with long-range missiles fired from the ground and air, coupled with drones that can swarm the enemy like locusts. This is what is happening

▲ **March 11, 2019**

presently between Pakistan and India, without a formal declaration of war. Discounting Kargil, this is the first time in the world that two nuclear-armed countries are fighting a modern, tech-enabled hot war.

This is a no-win war. Neither wants to occupy the other's territory. India only wants Pakistan to mend its ways. Stop cross-border terrorism. But Pakistan refuses to acknowledge the folly of its surrogate war strategy, its 'war of a thousand cuts' against India. In the past 25 years, this is the fifth major confrontation between the two countries. After the December 2001 attack on Parliament and the 2008 mass shootings of Mumbai, India held its hand, acceding to US-led mediation that rested on promises to get Pakistan to stamp out terror groups, including by a global squeeze on funds. Prime Minister Narendra Modi shifted the template to punitive deterrence with the post-Uri and Pulwama strikes in 2016 and 2019. But things didn't escalate then, with major powers intervening. This time, by contrast, it has blown up into a full-scale conflict as there is no great power blowing the whistle. President Trump is distracted by his own chaotic agenda. Russia is too engrossed with Ukraine. China is not a neutral party as Pakistan is beholden to it for its weapons and economy. This gives it more leverage over it than any other country, but it's difficult to decipher its foreign policy. The geopolitical situation then is not conducive for an external brokering of a mutually satisfactory truce, as in the past.

In this issue, Group Editorial Director Raj Chengappa and Deputy Editor Pradip R. Sagar analyse Pakistan's dangerous gambit and how India could thwart it. India has the logistical edge in conventional terms, be it in troop strength (1.2 million vs 550,000) or weapon systems (4,200 vs 2,627 tanks). This is partly offset by the turf, some of it mountainous, and spatial dimensions. With a longer border, India has other fronts to consider. All the interest now is in new-gen weaponry: precision offence and defence missile systems, novel instruments like kamikaze drones, and accurate surveillance. The only real deterrent to Pakistan's misdeeds is for India to invest more in defence and maintain undeniable superiority. India can afford it. Pakistan cannot. However, while 'Make in India' is a laudable goal, it is slow to bear fruit. The immediate need is to streamline our procurement processes and buy the best weapons globally. For lasting peace, the Pakistan army must permanently abandon its old playbook. The tactic of keeping India as the bogey to justify power is long past its sell-by date. Only by shedding this can the subcontinent move from bombs to dialogue.

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